

Some of us are content with our PCs the way they are, most want better hardware, some have the best hardware around; what now? Take a metal cutter and rip holes in your cabinet, that's what...

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What is the first thing that grabs your attention when you look at a computer? The monitor that looks and behaves very much like its idiot sibling, or the bulky, staid-looking cabinet that is ugly and unaesthetic?

Most would be attracted to the monitor. If it's a flat screen LCD, you might have to wipe some drool off the computer desk. Yes, even older people find it difficult to control that aspect of instant infatuation. But the solid cabinet that houses all the essential parts of the machine will be treated as a non-existent piece of hardware—its bulk notwithstanding.

A few companies do try to jazz up the cabinet by adding a few extra LEDs (Light Emitting Diodes) in the front and on the sides, or a few extra fans on the side to give it a supposed "space age" feel. But that's just about as far as it goes. None of the cabinets available in the market will actually grab your attention. At best, you'd have a choice of a black over the normal white ones.

But there are a bunch of people out there who want to customise every single aspect of their machine. Though small, this tribe is near fanatical in their approach and goes to great lengths to modify (or mod) their PCs.

For the uninitiated, to mod a PC means customising the cabinet or case. This could be as simple as adding a few extra LEDs along the sides of your PC case to more complex things like cutting a window into the side, adding fans, UV tubes, and in extreme cases, water cooling your PC and redoing your mouse and keyboard.

Working with tools such as glass and metal cutters, acrylic paints, LEDs and soldering tools, these guys take great pleasure in ripping apart the cabinet and adding their extra two bits, anything to have their own signature style.

One such mod warrior is Nimish Thacker. This 24-year-old engineering graduate has always been

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fascinated by the thought of customising his PC cabinet. "An article that appeared in *Digit* back in 2002 is what enthused me to give modding some serious thought," says Nimish.

The thought stuck and Nimish was soon hunting around for the tools that would make his cabinet stand out. He points out that computer cases are the most neglected component of a new buy. "This trend is prevalent especially amongst the first timers. The general concept is to buy the cheapest, decent looking cabinet and save money for the rest of the hardware," he adds.

Mod Star

So what is the first thing that a wannabe Mod Star needs to keep in mind? Nimish has a few tips: "First, you need to make sure that the cabinet should be spacious and well built. A spacious cabinet means there will be ample air flow and a sturdy one will lend itself to be cut and drilled."

Whoa, did someone talk about cutting and drilling? Who would take a whirring blade close to their precious motherboard? Well it's not as difficult and macabre as it sounds. As Nimish puts it, all you need is some creativity, freakish experimental streak (things do go a little awry sometimes) and a small bit of moolah to stock up all the standard equipment you'd need.

Tools like a soldering iron, cutting blades and sandpaper can be bought from any hardware shop. Cutting tools like a circular rotating blade are slightly more expensive. Most modders like Nimish swear by Dremel. This North American manufacturer churns out some of the best cutting tools.

Other necessary equipment for any mod such as PCBs (Printed Circuit Boards), LEDs and can be bought from any electrical store. The most common LEDs are the red ones but if you want your case to be cool then you can get either blue or white ones. These however come at a premium. In case your case design requires an LED tube then you've got to be ready to shell out a lot more.



Part of the fun while modding is using tools like this cutter

Equipment List	
Equipment	Cost (Rs)
Soldering iron with solder	250
Dremel	1600
Blades	20
Diamond blade	50
Sanding paper	20
LEDs	3-5 for white and blue LEDs
LED lighting tube	800
UV lighting tube	1000
General Purpose PCB	8
Can of acrylic paint	250 (depending on the colour)
Acrylic sheet for window	30 for each